

include it in a “bundle.” Granting an Acuity to an Attribute with no conditions attached should probably be the whole of the Birthright, particularly for Physical and Mental Attributes (as they are rolled more often).

## Magic

The most common form of Birthright, a Magic Birthright grants the members of the kith a special trick or feat that they can accomplish. Many of the existing Birthrights, including a pooka’s ability to shapeshift, a piskey’s talent for vanishing, and a sluagh’s prowess for slithering into tight places fall into this category. This type of Birthright is also the most challenging to design and for the Storyteller to adjudicate. Consider the follow design principles:

- **Make it Magical:** The Birthright should allow the changeling to do something that human beings either *cannot* do or *cannot do without extensive work*. A boggan can analyze the social dynamics of a group with a glance and some quick conversation. Even an adept mortal would require hours of conversation and careful observation to do this.

- **Expenditure?** Some Birthrights require the expenditure of a point of Glamour; most do not. It’s not impossible for a Birthright to necessitate spending a point of Willpower or even to cost the changeling a Health level! Expenditure should be reserved for special, impressive Birthrights. Using them in play is an investment in the story on the player’s part, so the reward should be commensurate with that expenditure.

- **Dice Pool?** Most Magic Birthrights require a roll of some kind (though not all; pooka can change shape without a roll, and the redcap’s Dark Appetite never fails the kith). In general, the more closely the Birthright resembles a mundane action, the more likely it should have a dice pool.

- **Bundled with Acuity:** If a Magic Birthright is fairly minor or narrow in scope, the Storyteller might allow the player to include an Acuity Birthright with it. The Acuity must make sense as a natural extension of the Magic. For example, the sidhe cannot be made to look foolish, ever (clearly a Magic Birthright), and *as a result*, they are immune to botches on Etiquette rolls.

## Advantage

Advantage Birthrights are the rarest, but also the simplest, type. They simply bestow additional dots in a Trait, usually an Attribute.

Players should consider that adding dots to an Attribute makes a statement about the character’s prowess, particularly compared to mortals. The “ugliest” sidhe is attractive by mortal standards. The weakest troll is still as strong as an average mortal. If the kith as you’ve envisioned it is meant to be truly superlative in a given area, it makes sense to give the kith an Advantage Birthright.

Advantage Birthrights shouldn’t exceed one extra dot for Physical and Mental Attributes, and two extra dots for Social Attributes. Advantage Birthrights can also add Health levels (as with trolls) or even dots of Willpower. It’s recommended, however, that if a kith is meant to be particularly

strong willed, the Birthright allows the kith to regain Willpower in certain adversarial circumstances, rather than adding Willpower outright. Remember, a point of Willpower can be spent for an automatic success, which reduces the chance of a botch (see p. 258). Likewise, Advantage Birthrights shouldn’t add dots of Glamour without heavy restrictions, perhaps even a second Frailty.

## Step Four: Frailty

Mythological creatures almost always have some weakness. It might be a compulsive behavior, a substance or food that drives them away, an aversion to hearing their own name, or a way to trick them into servitude. When designing your kith, you must design a Frailty, some part of that kith’s story that restricts or harms it in some way.

When designing a Frailty, consider the following principles:

- **Story Possibility:** Pooka have to lie when asked a direct question. That means that when a pooka receives such a question, the story is about that pooka and his inability to give a straight answer. Yes, he *can* tell the truth with some effort, but remember that doing so requires a Willpower point — if the player makes the expenditure, she is invested in the character being honest in that moment and that should carry resonance, too. When designing a Frailty, think about what it does to the story when that Frailty comes into play. It should also allow interesting, challenging things to happen.

- **Applicability:** Frailties that are obscure, obtuse, or extremely hard to enact aren’t good enough. A Frailty should come up in play at least once every chapter, even in a minor way. Some Frailties (like the sluagh’s inability to speak above a whisper) are constant, but relatively minor. Others, like a selkie’s vulnerability upon losing the seal skin, won’t cause problems often, but when they do they can drive a whole story. Either is fine, but the Frailty shouldn’t be something the player can just pay lip service to and then ignore.

- **Avoid Direct Damage:** It can be tempting to say that the kith suffers physical damage from a particular source; perhaps a certain plant is poison, or perhaps a nocturnal kith suffers damage from sunlight. These kinds of Frailties are hard to use in play, however, because if the Storyteller employs them, she reduces the character’s effectiveness considerably until the damage heals. The threat of such damage can be motivating, but it still acts as a limiter on the character’s actions rather than as a way to spur interesting scenes. Taking damage is not, in itself, a very interesting event in a game; the context for the damage is what brings the drama.

Frailties fall into three general categories:

## Compulsions

Most existing Frailties are Compulsions. They require that a character perform a particular action. In some cases, this is a full-time behavior (sluagh *always* whisper, pooka *always* lie), while in other cases the character must perform a particular action under certain circumstances (boggans must help people in need, piskies must try to steal objects that catch their fancy). Often, characters can resist these Compulsions if the player